

# Understanding CommonLine

## What is CommonLine?

CommonLine is a standardized format and delivery process for the exchange of loan data between schools and their student loan providers. It was developed and is maintained by the Electronic Standards Committee of the National Council of Higher Education Loan Programs (NCHELP).

The CommonLine format is a fixed-length file format used in the student loan industry to send files to and from schools, lenders, servicers and guarantors participating in student loan transactions. Not all schools use CommonLine format files. Schools can send proprietary format files to ELMNet. Lenders, servicers and guarantors send only CommonLine files to ELMNet.

## What does a CommonLine record look like?

This is a sample CommonLine header and trailer record:

|                   |                                                                                                           |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Record terminator | @HPS 1999ES01120550012005011216365420050112000000CHANGE TRANS C004PUNCG<br>00297600 SELMRES ELMRES P<br>* |
|                   | @T00056800000020050112163654C004PUNCG 00297600 ELMRES<br>ELMRES<br>*                                      |

A fixed-length file format requires that specific data be placed at exact positions within the file. The starting position and length of each field is listed in the CommonLine specifications. If the data does not fill up all of the space allotted for that data, then blank spaces are used to fill the remaining spaces (some numeric fields use zeroes). The asterisk \* is used as a record terminator (indicating the end of a record).

## What are the CommonLine file types?

There are four main types of files used in CommonLine versions 4 and 5: Application Send, Change Transaction Send, Response, and Disbursement Roster files. A school creates and sends Application Send and Change Transaction Send files to ELMNet for processing. ELMNet transmits Response and Disbursement Roster files from lenders, servicers and guarantors to schools to update their SIS (school information system) records. Lenders and servicers also send Disbursement Roster files to ELM NDN.

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## What is an Application Send file?

The Application Send (AppSend) file is used to submit loan application data for initial processing. This file type is also used to submit subsequent processing requests, such as correction requests, reprint requests, and termination requests. Schools may also use this record to request disbursement holds and releases. Finally, this file may be used for a school's response to a school certification request.

Schools create and send CommonLine Application Send files to ELMNet with the naming convention *MMDDYY##.SIS*, where *##* is a two-digit sequence number.

|                                   |                                                                                   |                                                        |      |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|------|
| Header                            | @HPS001998                                                                        | 2005100408302920051004083029COMMON APPLICATIONSA004ELM | ELM  |
|                                   | CENTRAL INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY00000300                                           | SELM                                                   |      |
|                                   | RES D                                                                             |                                                        |      |
|                                   | *                                                                                 |                                                        |      |
| Detail                            | @1ATEST                                                                           | GRANT A0000345678902 ELM STREET                        |      |
|                                   | SAN FRANCISCO                                                                     | CA900090000416602569000907510000702CS031000            |      |
|                                   | YYY000000000126540000P014408                                                      | 000000                                                 |      |
|                                   | 0000000000000000                                                                  | 01215400 2009876543210809B                             |      |
|                                   | F20080809416400000000000008500225000000020050907200602032006060900000000020051004 |                                                        |      |
|                                   | 000000000000                                                                      | 82907600000000000000000000                             | 706M |
| Supplemental Borrower Information | ME6431215                                                                         | RRRR S                                                 |      |
|                                   | PG W                                                                              | 00000000000000000000000000000000                       |      |
|                                   | 000000000                                                                         |                                                        | *    |
|                                   | @7NCLP01gtest@elmresources.com                                                    |                                                        |      |
|                                   | Y20051011                                                                         |                                                        |      |
|                                   | *                                                                                 |                                                        |      |
| Trailer                           | @T000004000000020051004083029A004PELM INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY00000300             | ELM                                                    |      |
|                                   | ELM RES                                                                           | 00000000000000000004                                   |      |
|                                   | *                                                                                 |                                                        |      |

The parts of an AppSend file are:

- **Header** – The header record starts with the code **@H**. The header record identifies the sender and receiver of the file, and identifies the file as an AppSend file. The header record is required.
- **Detail** – The Application Send detail record starts with the code **@1**. It contains the basic fields used in processing the loan application. This record is required.
- **Supplemental** – The unique supplemental detail record starts with the code **@2**. This record is used by the lender to address unique services that are not standard to CommonLine. This record is optional.
- **Alternative Loan Detail** – The Alternative loan detail record starts with the code **@4**. It contains additional fields for Alternative loans. This record is optional.
- **Reference Detail** – The reference detail record starts with **@5**. It contains additional fields for borrower reference information. This record is optional.
- **Supplemental Borrower Information** – The supplemental borrower information detail record starts with **@7**. It contains fields for additional information, such as the borrower's employer, co-signer, and borrower reference information. This record is optional.
- **Trailer** – The trailer record begins with **@T**. This record summarizes the preceding records and provides totals that can be used to verify transmission. This record is required.

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## What is a Change Transaction Send file?

A Change Transaction Send file is used to submit loan changes for guaranteed loans. These changes include loan period changes, cancellations, reinstatements, reissues, school refunds, reallocations, loan increases, hold/release flag changes, and borrower e-mail changes.

Schools send Change Transaction Send files with the naming convention *MMDDYY##.CLC* or *MMDDYY##.SPC*. The files are sent with a *.SPC* extension if there is mapping in place to change or add data to a school's file. If no data is added, and there is no mapping in place, then the file is sent with a *.CLC* extension.

|                                                  |                                                                                                                                                              |
|--------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Header                                           | @HPS 20040026962005482005101000000020051010000000CHANGE TRANS C004PELM<br>UNIVERSITY 00269600 SNSHESC 736<br>P065972838677150541                             |
| Borrower<br>Detail Record                        | *<br>@10205574973400266600 736 SMITH<br>JOHN J19800429 2005101000000000000012345678917150941                                                                 |
| Loan<br>Cancellation/<br>Reinstatement<br>Record | *<br>@10800074993400266600 736 00000000SF<br>20050825828454 200508272006051800 00266600001FCX0G1002005101000000000<br>20051010000000000000000345678917150941 |
| Trailer                                          | *<br>@T00000300000020051010000000C004PELM UNIVERSITY 00266600 NYSHESC<br>736 065872828917250961<br>*                                                         |

The parts of a Change Transaction Send file are:

- **Header** – The header record starts with the code *@H*. The header record identifies the sender and receiver of the file, and identifies the file as a Change Transaction Send file. The header record is required.
- **Detail** – The Change Transaction Send detail records start with the code *@1*. These records contain the basic fields used in processing the loan application. The detail records are:
  - **Borrower Detail Record** – This record starts with the code *@1-02*. The record contains information about the borrower. There must be one Borrower Detail Record in the file for each borrower.
  - **Loan Period Change Detail Record** – This record starts with the code *@1-07*. The record is used to submit changes to loan period begin and end dates, student's grade level, and student's anticipated completion date.
  - **Loan Cancellation/Reinstatement Detail Record** – This record starts with the code *@1-08*. The record is used to submit loan cancellations and reinstate previously cancelled loans.
  - **Disbursement Cancellation/Change Detail Record** – This record starts with the code *@1-09*. The record is used to submit disbursement cancellations, reinstate previously cancelled disbursements, and reschedule disbursement dates prior to the release of funds.

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- **Disbursement Notification/Change Detail Record** – This record starts with the code @1-10. The record is used to submit disbursement cancellations, reissue requests, and reinstatements after the release of funds.
- **School Refund Detail Record** – This record starts with the code @1-11. This record is used to report school refund information.
- **School Refund Correction Detail Record** – This record starts with the code @1-12. The record is used to correct previously submitted school refund information.
- **Sub/Unsub Reallocation Loan Decrease Detail Record** – This record starts with the code @1-13. The record is used to perform reallocations when a loan reduction is involved.
- **Sub/Unsub Reallocation Loan Increase Detail Record** – This record starts with the code @1-14. The record is used to perform reallocations when a loan increase is involved.
- **E-Mail Information** – This record starts with the code @1-19. The record is used to request changes to a borrower's e-mail address.
- **Loan Increase Detail Record** – This record starts with the code @1-24. The record is used to request loan increases.
- **Supplemental** – The unique supplemental detail record starts with the code @2. This record is used by the lender to address unique services that are not standard to CommonLine. This record is optional.
- **Trailer** – The trailer record begins with @T. This record summarizes the preceding records and provides totals that can be used to verify transmission. The trailer record is required.

### What is a Response file?

A Response file is used to confirm that loan application data was received, identify errors, and report guarantee data. The lender or servicer acknowledges that a file was received, and that the requested action was carried out, or that an error prevented it. This file can be used to report modifications to previously reported guarantees, and terminations of loan applications. A Response file can be used to confirm change transaction data and identify errors with that data, and to submit school certification requests.

ELMNet sends CommonLine Response files with the naming convention *MMDDYY##.SUP*, *MMDDYY##.RDY*, *MMDDYY##.SP2*, and *MMDDYY##.IGR*.

- **.SUP** – The .SUP file contains Response file records created by lender, guarantor or servicer updates to ELMNet. This file may contain only guarantee updates if requested by school.
- **.RDY** – The .RDY file contains Response file records for certain loan records that are ready to disburse, based on a set of criteria selected by the school. The .rdy file is typically used by schools using the hold/release process with hold as their default.
- **.SP2** – The .SP2 file contains @1C certification request Response file records from lenders.

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- **.IGR** – Lender and guarantor Response files contain approvals, rejections, or denials of loan records, and have the extension **.IGR**.

| Header                            | @HPS 1998 2005092610110620050929101106COMMON RESPONSE R004PELM<br>RESOURCES ELM OELM UNIVERSITY 000003<br>P<br>*                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |  |  |  |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|--|--|
| Detail                            | @1I20050926TEST WILLIAM 5400370460019 ELM<br>UNIVERSITY OAKLAND<br>CA941190000N/A 19800506SF999999 YY200509200013260001000732700 000000<br>000000000000000000 00132600 2005091920060615A<br>F20110615000000000000000008500000000000020050915 000000000000<br>834062085000000000000000000000 00000 706M N<br>2005091200000000000000000000000000000000000000000000000002006032700<br>000000000000000000000000000000000000000000000000000000000000SY<br>CAD1227937 HHH 000012274018<br>N 000000000000000000ASGU20050926 00000000<br>00000000 00000000000000000000000000004700PG N000000000000000<br>* |  |  |  |
| Reference Response                | @5NCLP04TEST SUE 0000000000P819 12TH ST<br>ANY TOWN OR9700900005036440490STUDENT<br>ADAM 0000000000P1000 CROPRELM DR<br>ANY TOWN CA9300300008056589811<br>0000000000<br>0000000000<br>*                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |  |  |  |
| Supplemental Borrower Information | @7NCLP02<br>3019 ELM UNIVERSITY OAKLAND<br>CA941100000<br>*                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |  |  |  |
| Trailer                           | @T0000020000000000000020050926101106R004PELM RESOURCES ELM<br>ELM UNIVERSITY 00003 00000000000200000000000002<br>*                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |  |  |  |

The parts of a Response file are:

- **Header** – The header record starts with the code @H. This record identifies the sender and receiver of the file, and identifies the file as a Response file. The header record is required.
- **Detail** – The Response detail record starts with the code @1. It contains the basic fields used in processing the loan application. This record is required.
- **Supplemental** – The unique supplemental detail record starts with the code @2. This record is used by the lender to address unique services that are not standard to CommonLine. This record is optional.
- **Special Messages** – The special messages detail record starts with the code @3. The special messages detail record contains text messages that are related to an error, or are informational.
- **Alternative Loan** – The Alternative loan detail record starts with the code @4. It contains additional fields for Alternative loans. This record is optional.
- **Reference Response** – The reference response detail record starts with the code @5. It contains additional fields for borrower reference information. This record is optional.

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- **Change Transaction Error** – The change transaction error detail record starts with the code @6. This record provides a copy of the original change transaction that caused the error, and explains up to five errors that caused the loan record to be rejected.
- **Supplemental Borrower Information** – The supplemental borrower information detail record starts with @7. It contains additional fields for supplemental borrower information. This record is optional.
- **Trailer** – The trailer record begins with @T. This record summarizes the preceding records and provides totals that can be used to verify transmission. This record is required.

## What is a Disbursement Roster?

A Disbursement Roster is used to report disbursement data to schools.

ELMNet sends a school CommonLine Disbursement Roster files with the naming convention *MMDDYY##.DSB*, *MMDDYY##.DS2*, *MMDDYY##.EFT* and *MMDDYY##.RST*. The *.DSB* and *.DS2* files are ELM NDN disbursements, and the files are created by ELM NDN. If the school is receiving all of their loan disbursement information in one roster, they receive a *.DSB* file. If they receive two separate files (one for FFELP and one for alternative loans), they receive both the *.DSB* and the *.DS2*. The *.EFT* and *.RST* files are disbursements which are sent to the school directly from another disbursing agent, and are created by the disbursing agent.

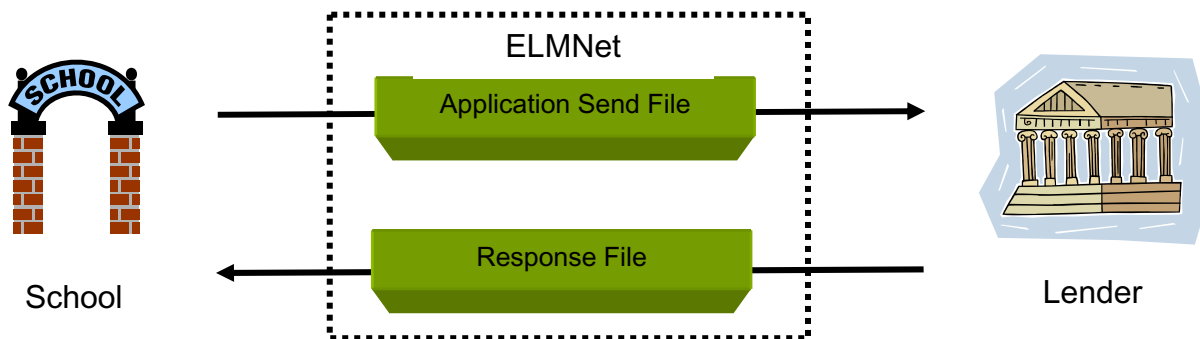
[illegible]

The parts of a Disbursement Roster file are:

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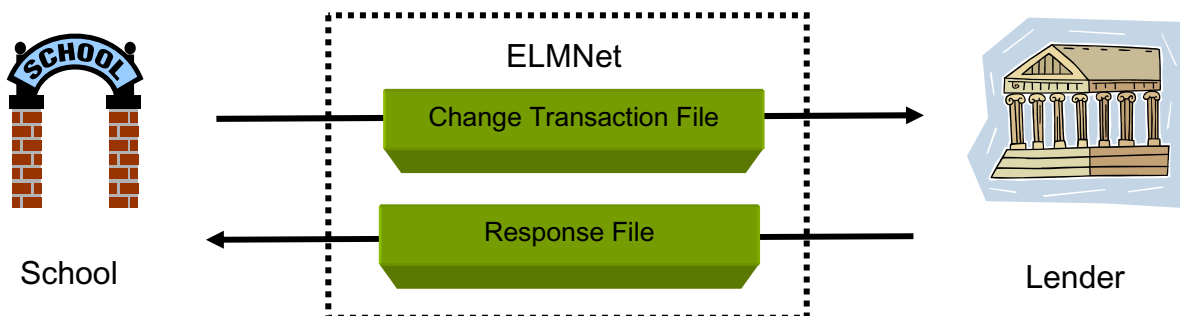
- **Header** – The header record starts with the code **@H**. The header record identifies the sender and receiver of the file, and identifies the file as a Disbursement Roster/Acknowledgment file. The header record is required.
- **Detail** – The Disbursement detail record starts with the code **@1**. It contains the basic fields used in processing the loan application. This record is required.
- **Supplemental** – The unique supplemental detail record starts with the code **@2**. This record is used by the lender to address unique services that are not standard to CommonLine. This record is optional.
- **Trailer** – The trailer record begins with **@T**. This record summarizes the preceding records and provides totals that can be used to verify transmission. This record is required.

### What is the document flow for CommonLine documents?



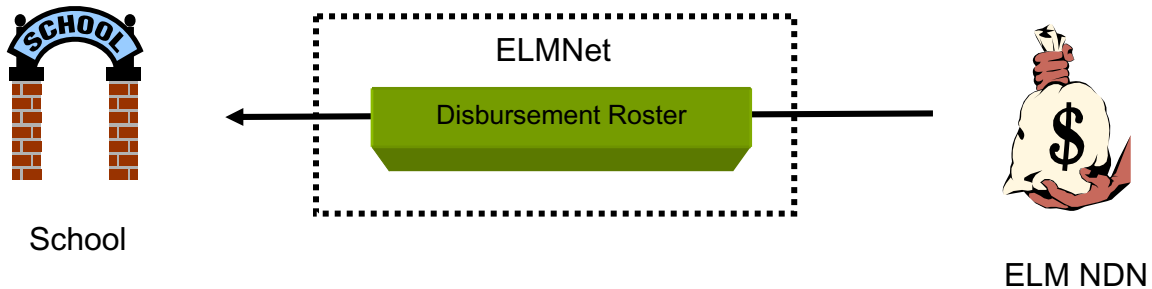
In a typical lender flow process, loan applications are transmitted as Application Send files by the school to ELMNet. The Application Send files are then transmitted to the lender or servicer. The lender or servicer transmits Response files to ELMNet, and the files are sent to the school. In a guarantor flow process (prior to 7/1/2010), Application Send files could have been sent to the guarantor.

If a school does not use CommonLine files, then the loan application is transmitted to ELMNet in a proprietary format file, translated into CommonLine format, and then transmitted to the lender or servicer.



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Change Transaction Send files are sent to ELMNet by a school when a change is made to a loan record. The Change Transaction Send file is then sent to the lender or servicer. Response files are used to respond to Change Transaction Send files.



Disbursement rosters are sent to the school by ELM NDN or other disbursing agent.

### What's a CLUID?

CLUID is an abbreviation for CommonLine unique identifier. The CLUID is an alphanumeric field which uniquely identifies a loan record, and which must be used in all CommonLine files referring to that loan record. The CLUID is assigned by the organization that transmits the first electronic record containing information about the loan application. The CLUID is usually created when the initial Application Send file is submitted. The CLUID can contain numbers and upper-case letters, and can be no more than seventeen characters long. It is made up of the participant ID, the participant branch ID, the system ID, and an incremental code.

### Where can I see CommonLine File Specifications?

File specifications for the different CommonLine files are available on the National Council of Higher Education Loan Programs website at [www.nchelp.org](http://www.nchelp.org).